GUIDE · FOR ANY STUDENT

How to Start Student Voice at Your School

What worked in Sun Prairie this year, written so another student can copy it.

1. Start with one clear letter

Write to your principal or School Board about one thing students are worried about. Say what happened, how it affects students, and two or three specific, doable asks. Keep it respectful. You're asking to be part of the solution, not blaming anyone.

2. Ask for a meeting, then write it down

Ask for 30 minutes. Bring a one-page handout. Take notes, and ask before recording. Within two days, email a short recap ("so we all leave with the same notes"). That recap is what turns a nice conversation into a commitment.

3. Get real input, not just your friends'

Run a short anonymous survey in every language families speak. Share it through teachers and newsletters, not only social media. Report who answered, including who's missing.

4. Keep a public record

Post short updates: what you asked, what you were told, what changed. A free website and an Instagram account are enough. Give district leaders a chance to correct anything before you post it, and set a deadline.

5. Track promises

Keep a "You said, we did" list. Every commitment gets an owner, a date and a status. Celebrate wins publicly; it's the best proof that speaking up works.

6. Join the groups that already exist

Work groups, Student Senate and Board student sessions are where decisions get made. Ask to join them before starting something new.

7. Protect people

- Don't post names of students, private phone numbers, or rumors about staff.
- Stick to facts from public records and the news.
- If someone tells you they're unsafe, help them reach a trusted adult right away.

8. Make it last after you graduate

Recruit co-leads from different grades and schools early. Share passwords and files with them. Push for something permanent, like an advisory council, so student voice doesn't depend on one person.

Handoff plan for SPASD Student Voice (Class of 2027 graduation): recruit 3 co-leads by December 2026, including one from East and one underclassman; share the Instagram, website and records with them by March 2027; co-leads run the April and May updates; full handoff by June 2027.

Templates for the letter, recap email and survey are on spasdstudentvoice.netlify.app. Written by Zackary Mark.